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A 'Chinese' Pagoda at Nagapattinam on the Tamil Coast: Revisiting India's Early Maritime Networks

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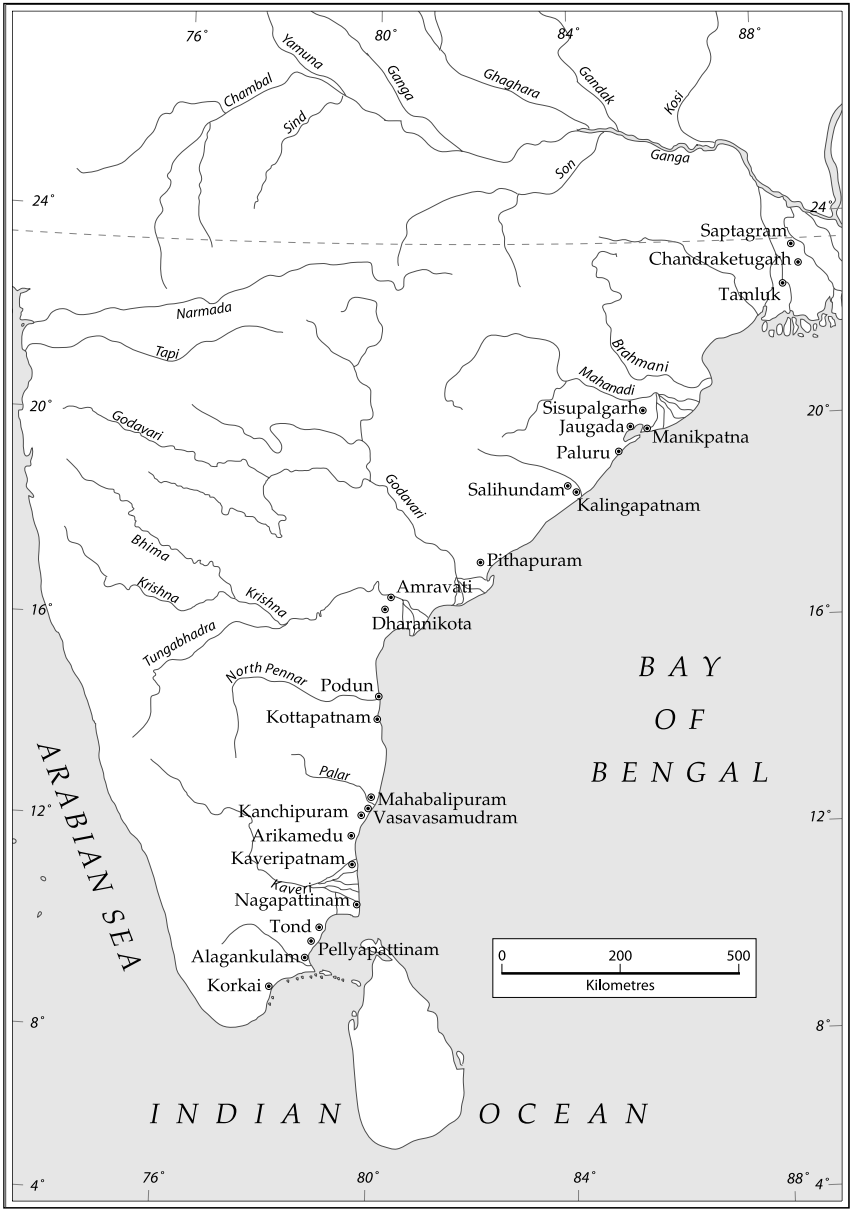
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A 'Chinese' Pagoda at Nagapattinam on the Tamil Coast: Revisiting India's Early Maritime Networks*

The maritime history of India has conventionally been treated as a history of trade contacts across the ocean, largely as a result of foreign stimulus and demand for 'oriental' luxuries from societies of the West. Historians have tended to marginalise contributions of maritime communities, as ancient Indian history has been studied through the perspective of agrarian expansion and the caste structure often seen as inhibiting travel across the ocean. In this paper, the focus is on maritime cultural landscapes and the relationship between the sea and the land, which underlines the centrality of the coast; the communities who inhabited the space between the ocean and the hinterland; their histories and attempts at constructing their cultural environment.

The seaside town of Nagapattinam located on the Tamil coast has played an important role in the history of trans-oceanic activity across the Bay of Bengal. The present district of Nagapattinam, which came into being in 1991, is known to have been settled as early as the Neolithic period and provides evidence for continued activity well into the present. It was not only an important port and trading settlement, but was also a major sacred centre, as evident from the 16th century dargah, which continues to be a focus of pilgrimage, as also the 17th century basilica of Our Lady of Good Health at Velankanni, 10 kilometres from Nagapattinam. Thirty-one devotional couplets of the 7th century Tamil saints Appar and Sambandar describe Nagapattinam as a prosperous city with fortification

*Lecture delivered by Himanshu Prabha Ray at the India International Centre on November 15, 2014



Ports and Trade Centres along the East Coast of India
(Map drawn by Ms Uma Bhattacharya)

walls and wide roads. Large ships known as *vangam* anchored along the coast, as it was a major centre for onward travel to Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia[1].

Chinese records of the 1060s and 1070s show the significance of the site for missions said to have been sent to the Imperial Court from the Chola kingdom of south India as well as from the ruler of Sriwijaya located on the island of Sumatra. By the last decades of the 11th century, the Chinese court had begun to encourage Chinese traders to venture out to sea. In 852 and 871, the southeast Sumatran port-state of Jambi (formerly at the heart of Sriwijaya's kingdom) is known to have sent its own trade missions to China. Nagapattinam was known for the presence of the Cudamanivihara established in the 10th and 11th century by the king of Sriwijaya. The Chola kings record donations made to the vihara, which continued as a major landmark until the 19th century. These and other references found in Chinese writings and Chola inscriptions further corroborate the maritime links of Nagapattinam with Sri Lanka, Indonesia and China.

Nagapattinam was by no means an isolated site. Instead, archaeological data from the Tamil coast indicates the presence of 127 contemporary Buddhist sites,[2] which complement those that have been located further north along the Bengal, Orissa and Andhra coasts and underscores the vitality and vibrancy of Buddhism in the early medieval period.

This paper locates the Buddhist monastic complex at Nagapattinam within the larger context of the East Coast, thereby challenging the theory of the decline of Buddhism in the Indian subcontinent around the 7th–8th century propounded by Alexander Cunningham, the first Director-General of the Archaeological Survey of India in the 19th century. It is divided into two sections: the first section presents the cultural context of the Buddhist vihara at Nagapattinam; while in the second section we discuss the wider linkages of the site of Nagapattinam within the multi-religious linkages of trade guilds from south India. This paper

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[1] Gokul Seshadri, New Perspectives on Nagapattinam, Hermann Kulke, K. Kesavapany, Vijay Sakhuja edited, *Nagapattinam to Suvarnadwipa: Reflections on the Chola Naval Expeditions*, Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, Singapore, 2009: 107-8.

[2] http://www.pnclink.org/pnc2011/english/ppt/D.%20DAYALAN.pdf accessed on 2 May 2012.

thus shifts the focus from studying the period from the 8th–9th to the 12th–13th centuries largely through the perspective of Indian feudalism or by according centrality to the political structure or trade in initiating change, to understanding the archaeology of coastal centres such as at Nagapattinam as maritime cultural landscapes and as important centres for religious learning. The objective is to highlight the distinctive features of the Buddhist monastic complex at Nagapattinam and to understand it within the multi-religious milieu of the Tamil coast.

Cudamanivihara at Nagapattinam

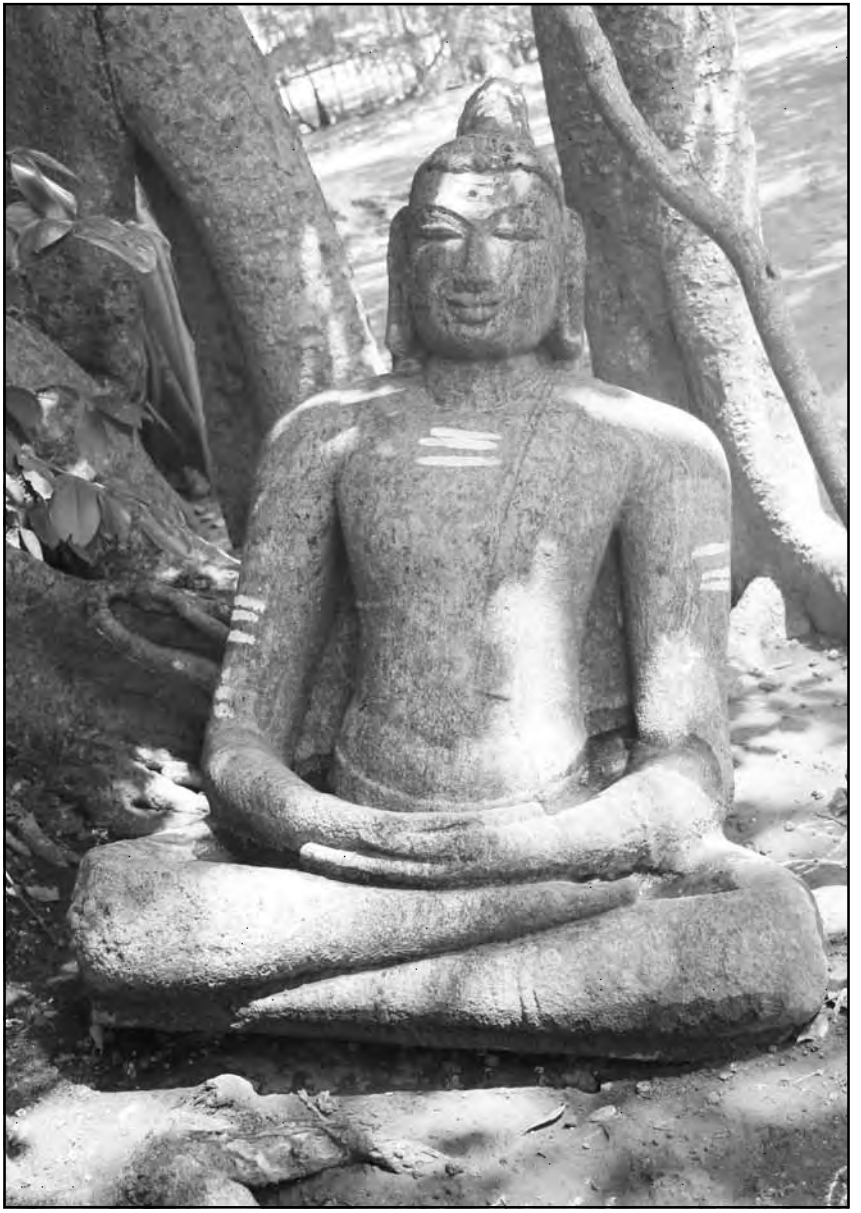
The two sets of Leyden copper plates, the Larger Leyden Plate and Smaller Leyden Plates in Sanskrit and Tamil refer to the establishment of the Cudamanivihara at Nagapattinam at the initiative of the kings of Sriwijaya. Construction started during the reign of the Chola King Rajaraja I (985–1016) and was completed under his son and successor Rajendra I (1012–1044). The Smaller Leyden Plates in Tamil refer to nine units of land attached to the Nagapattinam vihara.[3] The larger plates contain a Sanskrit portion, consisting of 111 lines, and a Tamil portion, consisting of 332. The Sanskrit text states that in the 21st regnal year, the king gave the village of Annaimangalam to the lofty shrine of Buddha in the Chulamanivarma vihara, which the ruler of Sriwijaya and Kataha, Mara Vijayottungavarman of the Sailendra family with the *makara* crest, had erected in the name of his father in the delightful city of Nagappattana. After Rajaraja passed away, his son Madhurantaka caused a permanent edict to be made for the village granted by his father. It is mentioned that the height of the vihara towered above Kanaka Giri or Mount Meru.[4] Nagapattinam also finds mention in the 1467 Kalyani inscription of the Burmese king Dhammaceti. Some Burmese monks who were ship-wrecked are said to have visited Nagapattinam and worshipped there.[5]

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[3] Peter Schalk edited, *Buddhism among Tamils in Pre-Colonial Tamilakam and Ilam*, Uppsala University, Stockholm, volume II, 2002: 513-670.

[4] Seshadri, 2009: 125.

[5] Schalk, volume II, 2002: 596. (NOTE: Since Schalk has been shortened after first appearance, the same has been done to Sesadri and other such instances across the paper - thanks).



Buddha image at Pushpavanam, Nagapattinam
(Photo credit: Debdutta Ray)

The Dutch traveller Wouter Schouten visited the Tamil coast in the 1660s and described a brick structure at Nagapattinam that he termed the 'Chinese Pagoda', an account repeated by a Dutch priest François Valentyn in his 1724 publication. The structure was extant until the 19th century. Sir Walter Elliot visited the Chinese Pagoda in 1846 on board the government steamer *Hugh Lindsay,* which travelled down the coast, and described it as a 'four-sided tower of three stories constructed of bricks closely fitted together without cement'.[6] There was a fort in its vicinity and 'about 11/3 miles NNW from the fort stands the old Black Pagoda, which is one of the most conspicuous objects in approaching this part of the coast'. In spite of local objections, the Governor-in-Council approved the demolition of the Buddhist monastery on 28 August 1867 by French Jesuits who had been expelled from Pondicherry and had wanted to construct a college in its place.

During the demolition of the monastery at Nagapattinam by the Jesuits in 1856, a large number of Buddhist bronze images were recovered. In a carefully concealed brick chamber, five bronze images of the Buddha were found, one of them with a Tamil inscription on the pedestal, which reads: 'Hail Prosperity! The Nayakar (Buddha), who assured the salvation of scholarly Pandits who learnt the Agama (Nikaya).'[7] Three hundred and fifty Buddhist bronzes were discovered between 1856 and the 1930s at Vellipalayam and Nanayakkara street in Nagapattinam. Subsequent finds of Buddha images made in 1910 and 1935 were distributed to several museums, including the museums in Madras and the British Museum. Another 42 stunning Buddha bronzes and three Buddha artefacts in stone were found in 2004 in nearby Sellur village, Kodavasal taluq, Tiruvarur district, Tamil Nadu. They are all datable from the 11th to the 13th century CE.[8]

The bronzes may be divided into two broad categories: images of the Buddha; and votive stupas. In addition to representations of the Buddha, images of Avalokitesvara, Maitreya, Lokesvara, Jambhala, Vasudhara and Tara have also

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[6] Sir Walter Elliot, The Edifice Formerly Known as the Chinese or Jaina Pagoda at Negapatam, *The Indian Antiquary*, vol. 7, 1878: 224-7.

[7] T.N. Ramachandran, *The Nagapattinam and Other Buddhist Bronzes in the Madras Museum*, Government Press, Madras,1954: 19-21.

[8] T. S. Subramanian, Stunning Indicators of Nagapattinam's Buddhist Legacy, *The Hindu*, 25 December 2011.

been found, though smaller in number. Some of them carry inscriptions in Tamil on their pedestals dated from the 11th to the 13th century. Three categories of inscriptions are common: those containing epithets of the Buddha; inscriptions recording setting up of images by monks and nuns; and legends consisting of gifts by lay devotees. The longest and perhaps the most interesting is the two-line legend on the pedestal of a 69.2 cm Buddha image now in the John D. Rockfeller III collection. The 2002 decipherment of the inscription reads as follows:

> The image of the Lord Buddha is for festival procession(s) at the temple of the Lord Buddha attached to the *akkacāla ipperumpaḷḷi* or image house of *Rajendracolapperumpaḷḷi.*
>
> This image of the Lord Buddha has been installed by the venerable Kuṉṟakara IV of Ciṟutavūr.
>
> Hail Prosperity! The prefect of artisan manufactories for the merchants of the eighteen countries.[9]

Thus the Buddha image was invested with attributes of divinity and was involved in several rituals with close parallels to those associated with Shiva and Vishnu. Two monastic institutions were located at Nagapattinam, viz. the Cudamanivihara and the *Rajendracolapperumpaḷḷi.* The inscriptions from Nagapattinam thus provide evidence for the presence of several monastic orders and gifts by monks and nuns to the Sangha. Pauline Scheurleer suggests that some of the bronze images of the Buddha made in Java in the 9th century used models from Nagapattinam bronzes.[10]

A hoard of 45 bronzes was found more recently at Sellur village, Kodavasal taluq, Tiruvarur district of Tamil Nadu. The images range in height from 7 to 52 cm and include some extraordinary pieces, such as a votive stupa, about 30 cm tall.

> On the base of the stupa, around the four sides, are tales from the Buddha's life. On the one side is Nalagiri, the mad elephant kneeling before the

[9] Schalk, volume II, 2002: 595.

[10] Marijke J. Klokke and Pauline Lunsingh Scheurleer edited, *Ancient Indonesian Sculpture*, KITLV Press, Leiden, 1994: 78.

> Buddha on hearing his voice, and the Buddha calming it with his hand. On another side is the Buddha preaching his very first sermon, after his Enlightenment, in the Deer Park of Isipatana, now called Sarnath, near Varanasi. Below him is a Dharma Chakra, flanked by two deer and followers with folded hands. Below this panel is a standing Buddha, with an attendant holding a parasol with a tall stem above the Buddha's head. On another side is the Buddha in Maha Parinirvana, that is after his death. On the fourth side is a seated Buddha, with his right hand in 'bhoomi sparsa' mudra. On top of this base is the circular 'anda' and above it is the 'harmika' or the tiered vimana. Lift the anda and the harmika and, lo and behold, there emerges a tiny seated Buddha.[11]

Another is a 52 cm image of the seated Buddha with musicians playing various instruments around him.

An analysis of the inscriptions on the bronzes shows that many of the epithets associated with notions of divinity and found in contemporary Shaiva and Vaishnava traditions were applied to the Buddha image, indicating considerable inter-religious and inter-cultural communication.[12] Schalk refers to three kinds of Buddhism at Nagapattinam: the first one is evident from bronze pedestal images, which show it to be close to Saivism so that it is difficult to differentiate between the two. The second is documented in the 12th century text the *Viracoliyam* and its commentary, which propagates a devotional form of Buddhism mediated by the sage Agastya. The third form of Buddhism was that of the acaryas or the teachers. Very little of this last form survives, except in the form of stone images from several sites along the Tamil coast.[13]

We have earlier referred to the vihara at Nagapattinam, which received gifts from the kings of Southeast Asia and China as a part of the linkages between the Tamil coast, Sumatra and China. A second Buddhist circuit evident between

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[11] http://www.thehindu.com/features/friday-review/history-andculture/stunning-indicators-of-nagapattinams-buddhist-legacy/article2745233.ece accessed on 3 April 2014.

[12] Schalk, volume II, 2002: 603.

[13] Schalk, volume II, 2002: 517.

the well-known centre of Nalanda, the Bengal, Andhra and Orissa coasts and the Indonesian archipelago, as evident from the travels of the renowned Buddhist teacher Atiśa Dipankara will be discussed below.

A Sanskrit inscription engraved on a large copper plate found in Nalanda in 1921 records that the king of the Pala Dynasty, Devapala (rule c. 810–847) allocated five villages to support a monastery established there by Maharaja Balaputradeva, lord of Suvarnavipa (Sumatra).[14] The inscription emphasises such religious tenets as '*bodhisattva*s well-versed in *tantra*s' and the copying of Buddhist texts. The inscription provides important details about the ancestry of Sriwijaya's ruler at the time. It records his claim that his maternal grandfather was King Dharmasetu, his mother was named Tārā. His fame is compared to that of the five Pandava brothers of the *Mahābhārata.* The inscription goes on to refer to families of Hindu deities including Śiva and Pārvatī, Indra and Paulomi, Viṣṇu and Lakṣmī, as well as Buddha, son of Queen Maya as analogous to the parents of Balaputra. It is important to place this interaction between Nalanda and the Indonesian archipelago within the larger context of Buddhist sites along the east coast of India, as also those on the island of Sumatra.

Hiram Woodward has suggested that a distinctive world of Mantrayana and Yogini Tantras pervaded Java and Sumatra, as also large parts of India from the 7th century onwards. 'A good argument can be made for treating Indonesia and India as an integral unit well into the ninth century'.[15] In this he counters the overview presented in Davidson's study based largely on textual sources and secondary writings.[16] Ronald M. Davidson's synthesis of early medieval Buddhism draws on the works of Indian historians, such as Ram Sharan Sharma writing on Feudalism with a focus on socio-economic transformations from the 6th to 13th

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[14] Hiranand Shastri, The Nalanda Copper Plate of Devapaladeva, *Epigraphia Indica*, 17, 7, 1924: 310-27.

[15] Hiram Woodward, Esoteric Buddhism in Southeast Asia in the Light of Recent Scholarship, *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, 35, 2 June 2004: 353.

[16] Ronald M. Davidson, *Indian Esoteric Buddhism: A Social History of the Tantric Movement*, Columbia University Press, New York, 2002.

century.[17] Davidson's thesis is that 'esoteric Buddhism is a direct Buddhist response to the feudalization of Indian society in the early medieval period, a response that involves the sacralization of much of that period's social world. Specifically, his book argues that the monk, or yogin, in the esoteric system configures his practice through the metaphor of becoming the overlord of a mandala of vassals, and issues of scripture, language, and community reflect the political and social models employed in the surrounding feudal society.'[18]

Important links in Woodward's unit are provided` by the sculptural and iconographic programmes of the stupa at Borobudur in central Java and the Tabo monastery in the western Himalayas. Both adopt a sequence of texts and depictions that parallel each other, i.e. the life of the Buddha according to the *Lalitavistara* and Sudhana's pilgrimage as detailed in the *Gandavyuha sūtra.* Providing a link between the western Himalayas, Andhra and Indonesia was the renowned *dhamma* teacher Atiśa (982–1054). As discussed by Sarat Chandra Das (1849–1917) based on Tibetan sources, Atiśa was born in the village of Vajrayogini of Vikrampur region identified with Dhaka in Bangladesh. At a young age he was ordained as a Buddhist monk and studied with several famous teachers. He is said to have studied with the master Dharmakīrti of Suvarnadvipa, identified with Sumatra from 1012 to 1024. He travelled to the Indonesian archipelago on board a merchant ship along with his students. On completion of his studies, he returned to Vikramshila. In 1042 he arrived in Tibet at the invitation of the king of Tibet and is considered the father of Tibetan Buddhism.[19]

How does the Buddhism of Tibet—the much-maligned esoteric Buddhism of the 19th century—relate to that of other sites in the Indian subcontinent? This is an issue that has been discussed in detail elsewhere, especially with reference to the identification in 19th and 20th century writings of peninsular India as the

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[17] R. S. Sharma, *Indian Feudalism*, Macmillan, New Delhi, 2006 (updated and revised theory, which first appeared in 1965). B. D. Chattopadhyaya in *The Making of Early Medieval India*, Oxford University Press, New Delhi, 1994: 167 states that the period between the 6th-7th and 12th-13th centuries showed developments vastly different from the society of the earlier period. 'State formation was a crucial agent of change in this respect, in the sense that it brought a measure of cohesion among local elements of culture by providing them a focus' (p.35).

[18] Davidson, 2002.

[19] Ruth Sonam translated and edited, *Atisha's Lamp for the Path*, Snow Lion Publications, Ithaca, New York, 1997: 7-17.

land of the Dravidian temple.[20] We return to the main theme of the Buddhist monastic complex at Nagapattinam in the next section.

Travel as Self-Identifier in Buddhism

In a paper dated 2009, Robert Buswell explored Indian ascetic traditions of itinerant wanderers and suggested that the travel impulse became an integral part of Buddhism's self-identity. He proposed that the motivation to travel was by no means restricted to the terrestrial world, but was deeply ingrained in Buddhist cosmology, as evident from massive anthologies of spiritual journeys (Buswell, 2009: 1055-1075).[21]

The Gaṇḍavyūha, part of the *Avatamsakasutra,* is an important text for the study of travel in early Buddhism. It dates back, in all probability, to the early centuries of the Common Era and describes the attainment of enlightenment through pilgrimage—the primary aim of the writing being to stress that constraints placed by fixed systems need to be overcome to attain full consciousness. Prince Sudhana is inspired to travel by the Bodhisattva Manjusri and advised to visit 53 'spiritual friends' in order to learn *bodhicarya* or 'the Bodhisattva practice' (Cleary, 1993: 47).[22] These enlightened people, according to the text, could belong to all walks of life and to all regions, because 'the wisdom and virtues of Buddha are in all people, but people are unaware of it because of their preoccupations'. [23] Historicity is of little account in this Buddhist text as the discourse is presented by trans-historical, symbolic beings representing various aspects of universal enlightenment.

For example, the Gaṇḍavyūha enjoyed great prestige and popularity among the Buddhist communities of Indonesia, China and Japan. The Chinese obtained the text from Khotan and propagated it in at least three different versions all over the Far East. In the third and last translation, the Gaṇḍavyūha occurs as an

[20] Himanshu Prabha Ray, *The Return of the Buddha: Ancient Symbols for a New Nation*, Routledge India, New Delhi, 2013.
[21] Robert E. Buswell Jr., Korean Buddhist Journeys to Lands Worldly and Otherworldly, *Journal of Asian Studies*, 68, 4, 2009: 1055-1075.
[22] T. Cleary, *The flower ornament Scripture*, Shambhala, Boston and London, 1993: 47.
[23] Cleary, 1993: 47.

individual text and not as a part of the Avataṁsakasūtra. The preservation and propagation of the Gaṇḍavyūha text in Indonesia may perhaps be discussed from a different perspective, i.e. its study and dissemination in the Mahayana monastic establishments. More importantly, its prominent sculptural representation at Borobudur in central Java highlights the significance of religious travel in early Javanese society.[24]

The somewhat slender narrative provided by the text of the Gaṇḍavyūha has been profusely sculpted on the 8th century Buddhist monument at Borobudur in central Java, though there are a number of variations between the sculpted panels and the textual data, and there is 'no clear correlation between the iconography and location of the narrative scenes and the corresponding passages in the text' (Fontein, 1967: 125).[25] The travel to Buddhist imaginaries no doubt helped break down the temporal and spatial barriers between the universal *dhamma* and local practices followed by lineages of Buddhist teachers.

There is reassertion of the vitality 'of a self-sustaining Bay of Bengal commercial network during the 1250–1500 period, which carried over into the next century. This network was inclusive of Pegu (Burma), Ayuddhya (Thailand), Vietnam and Khmer (Cambodia) cultural centres on the Southeast Asian mainland; the Melaka Straits region, inclusive of west Sumatra and the west coast of the Malay Peninsula; Bengal, Andhra and south India's Coromandel coastlines; as well as Sri Lanka.'[26] These movements across the ocean and the making of donations for establishing religious centres continue in later periods. How are these wider linkages of Nagapattinam to be assessed? In the next two sections, we discuss the issue from two perspectives: first from the point of view of the multi-cultural micro-context of the vihara at Nagapattinam, locating it within the diverse religious landscape of the Tamil coast; and second, within the larger macro-

[24] Himanshu Prabha Ray, Accumulation of Knowledge: Pilgrimage as Leitmotif in the Indian Ocean in the Ancient Period, Frans Hüsken and Dick van der Meij edited, *Reading Asia: New Research in Asian Studies*, Curzon Press, Richmond, 2001: 110-27.

[25] J. Fontein, *The pilgrimage of Sudhana. A study of Gandavyûha illustrations in China, Japan and Java*, Mouton, The Hague, 1967: 125.

[26] Kenneth R. Hall edited, *Structure and Society in Early South India: Essays in Honour of Noboru Karashima*, Oxford University Press, New Delhi, 2001: 24-25.

environment of trading guilds and travel by merchant groups across the Bay of Bengal.

The Vihara at Nagapattinam and its cultural context

The cultural context of Nagapattinam locates it within a multi-religious sacred geography, which preceded and succeeded the establishment of the Buddhist vihara at the site in 1005, rather than a sequential development of Buddhism followed by Hinduism, as often suggested. The Kayarohanaswami temple in Nagapattinam is dedicated to Shiva and is said to have 6th century origins, though the present structure is dated to the 11th century. Several 11th and 12th century inscriptions engraved on the temple walls provide valuable information. In addition to the setting up of the vihara, the king of Sriwijaya gave a set of ornaments and jewels to the silver image of Nakaiyalakar (the handsome lord of Nagapattinam) according to an inscription carved on the wall of the Shiva temple thereby corroborating a plural sacred landscape at Nagapattinam. A second record refers to donations of several types of lamps by the agent of the king of Sriwijaya, while a third mentions donations of gold coins from China for worship of an image of Ardhanarisvara installed on the premises of the temple by the king of Kidar identified with modern Kedah.[27]

Several 7th century Tamil saints, such as Saint Thirunavukkarasar (Appar), are known to have compiled devotional couplets in praise of Nagapattinam and its shrines.[28] Tamil tradition also refers to the semi-legendary saint Shahul Hamid of Nagore, whose 16th century shrine is situated a few kilometres to the north of Nagapattinam.[29] The site had several benefactors, all of whom contributed to structural additions to the shrine, including maraikkayar ship-owners, Nayak rulers, as also the Dutch East India Company.[30]

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[27] Seshadri, 2009: 121–25.
[28] Seshadri, 2009: 107–111.
[29] Sunil S. Amrith, Crossing the Bay of Bengal: the Furies of Nature and the Fortunes of Migrants, Harvard University Press, 2013: 88-9.
[30] Susan Bayly, *Goddesses and Kings: Muslims and Christians in South Indian Society 1700-1900*, Cambridge University Press, 1989: 217.

About 120 kilometres inland from Nagapattinam on the Kaveri river is the town of Tiruchirappalli with 7th and 8th century rock-cut shrines and a rock fort. Inscriptions at the highest parts of the fort date from the 3rd to the 11th century and record names of Jaina ascetics. About a kilometre from the fort is the mosque of Abdullah ibn Muhammad built in the 8th century.[31] This larger cultural landscape thus provides continuity to engagement of both the coastal and inland communities with the sea. It is important that this maritime orientation is taken into account when discussing the maritime history of coastal centres.

Besides, the multi-religious sacred landscape as evident from religious architecture is further corroborated by the textual evidence. In a study of the 11th century Tamil–Sanskrit poetic grammar text titled Viracoliyam, Anne Monius discusses the wider cultural context of the text, especially its relation to Saiva and Vaisnava devotional literature of the Chola period dated from the mid-9th to the mid-13th century CE.[32] The Chola period is marked by the 'emergence of new Tamil literary styles and genres, mature and confident in their vision of religious communities both Saiva and Vaisnava .... [which portray] Saiva and Vaisnava saints, as calm victors in debate over well-meaning but ignorant Buddhist monks.'[33] In contrast to this, writings in languages such as Pali of the Theravada monastic tradition depict south India as a bastion of conservative Buddhist orthopraxy during the Chola period. 'At the same time that Cekkilar imagines in literary Tamil the humble conversion to Saivism of the last remnants of Buddhism in the Tamil-speaking region, Buddhist monks writing in Pali increasingly identify themselves or are identified by others as "Coliya" or "Damila"'.[34] Clearly it is important to recognise cultural complexity in the Tamil region and the multiple linkages of the vihara at Nagapattinam, as also with merchant guilds across the Ocean, as discussed in the next section.

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[31] Leslie C. Orr, Gods and Worshippers on South Indian Sacred Ground, James Heitzman & Wolfgang Schenkluhn edited, The World in the year 1000, University of America Press, Lanham, 2004: 226 [225-254].

[32] Anne E. Monius, *Imagining a Place for Buddhism: Literary Culture and Religious Community in Tamil-Speaking south India*, Oxford University Press, Oxford – New York, 2001.

[33] Monius 2001: 122.

[34] Monius 2001: 123.

Trade Networks across the Bay of Bengal

From the 9th to the mid-14th centuries, several merchant associations dominated economic transactions in peninsular India, such as the Ainurruvar, Manigramam, Nanadesi and the Anjuvannam. Associated with these merchant associations were communities of craftsmen such as weavers, basket-makers, potters, leather-workers and so on. The topographical distribution of the inscriptions is significant and they are clustered in the Dharwad–Bijapur and Mysore localities of Karnataka, while in Tamil Nadu larger numbers are found in Thanjavur, Tiruchirapalli and Madurai districts. Not only did these merchant associations develop powerful economic networks, but also employed private armies. They donated regularly to temples, which were at times named after them and also contributed to the construction of tanks.[35]

Information about the organisation and functioning of the merchant guilds comes from inscriptions recording donations to temples and two types of assembly meetings are referred to.[36] One type, namely *pattana-dharmayam* (Kannada) or *pagudi* (Tamil), meaning shared contribution, are those that record decisions linked to contributions made to the temple; and the second refer to the founding of towns where merchants as well as soldiers lived (*erivira-pattinam*). The *pattana-dharmayam* inscriptions appear in Maharashtra and Karnataka in the 12th and 13th centuries, while they are clustered in Tamil Nadu in the 13th and 14th centuries. Most of the *erivira-pattinam* inscriptions in Tamil Nadu come from the 11th and 12th centuries, suggesting that at this time the importance of soldiers who guarded the merchants increased greatly. The range of their operations extended well beyond the boundaries of the Indian subcontinent into Southeast Asia.

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[35] Meera Abraham, *Two Medieval Merchant Guilds of South India*, Manohar Publishers, New Delhi, 1988. Noboru Karashima edited, *Ancient and Medieval Commercial Activities in the Indian Ocean: Testimony of Inscriptions and Ceramic Sherds*, Taisho University Press, Tokyo, 2002. Hermann Kulke, K. Kesavapany and Vijay Sakhuja edited, *Nagapattinam to Suvarnadwipa: Reflections on the Chola Naval Expeditions to Southeast Asia*, Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, Singapore, 2009.

[36] Noboru Karashima, South Indian Merchant Guilds in the Indian Ocean and Southeast Asia, Hermann Kulke, K. Kesavapany and Vijay Sakhuja edited, *Nagapattinam to Suvarnadwipa: Reflections on the Chola Naval Expeditions to Southeast Asia*, Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, Singapore, 2009: 135-157.

Several clusters of Tamil inscriptions have been found on the eastern fringes of the Indian Ocean from Burma (Myanmar) to Sumatra. Of the eight mid-9th to late-13th century Tamil or part-Tamil language inscriptions so far found in Southeast Asia, one has been found near Pagan in Burma; two just south of the Isthmus of Kra in the Malay peninsula; four in north and west Sumatra; and one on the central coast of China.[37] The earliest Tamil inscription was found on a hill, about 15 kilometres upstream on the Takuapa river, on the west coast of peninsular Thailand. It was associated with the remains of a small structure and three large stone figures of Shaiva affiliation. The inscription refers to the digging of a tank and a military camp set up for its protection.

There is a temporal gap of almost two centuries between the 9th century peninsular inscription of Takuapa and the earliest Tamil-language inscription found in Sumatra. This latter inscription dated 1088 CE was found at the early port site or *pattinam* (as mentioned in the inscription) of Lobo Tuwa, just to the north of Barus on the west coast of the island. This record refers to a tax levied on the captains and crew of incoming ships to the settlement on the island. An inscription from the north coast of Sumatra dated to the 12th century records trading regulations covering losses of goods, the waiving of collection of interest, and perhaps of royal fees. The last five of the known Tamil-language inscriptions of Southeast and East Asia appear to date to the second half of the 13th century. Perhaps the easternmost record is the bilingual Tamil and Chinese language inscription found associated with remains of one of the two Siva temples at Quanzhou in south China. These inscriptions connect merchant associations operating out of south India with the founding or the endowing of temples or other structures for the use of the resident Indian merchant community.

In the 10th century, local versions of these merchant guilds, termed the *banigrama,* appeared in the north coast ports of both Java and Bali, especially at Julah on the Balinese coast. There are seven Javanese inscriptions dating from 902 to

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[37] Jan Wisseman Christie, The Medieval Tamil-language inscriptions in Southeast Asia and China, *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, 29, 2, September 1998: 239-268.

1053 CE that refer to merchant associations called *banigrama* and to the various tax concessions granted to them. While some foreign merchants may have been included in these groups, these appear largely as indigenous organisations associated with the local economic networks as tax-farmers.[38]

A recent addition to the historiography on the subject focussed specifically on the 11th century naval expedition said to have been despatched against Sriwijaya by the Chola King Rajendra I is the edited volume titled *Nagapattinam* to *Suvarnadwipa: Reflections on the Chola Naval Expeditions to Southeast Asia*.[39] The papers in the volume suggest that the oft quoted Chola naval expedition is based on a single primary source, viz. the eulogy contained in the inscription of Rajendra I, which is not corroborated by other contemporary sources, especially Chinese sources. Instead, contemporary sources refer to an extensive Indian Ocean trading system extending from the Tamil coast to China and it is this trading system that provided a context to the supposed naval expedition. In the 11th century, Nagapattinam was a major outlet for the fertile hinterland along the river Kaveri and acquired pre-eminence amongst the series of towns that dotted the coast from Marakkanam north of Pondicherry to Korkai and Kayal in Tirunelveli district.

In the final analysis, it is evident that narratives of trans-locality, travel and pilgrimage across the seas lost their centrality with the development of 'scientific' disciplines such as archaeology and the search of national histories. The writing of ancient Indian history from a socio-economic perspective in India in the last six decades emphasised trade and urban centres as the prime movers of social change and the movements of brahmanas as legitimisers of political authority in newly emerging states of the early medieval period. It is important that as maritime history emerges as a discipline in its own right, the focus should shift from sequential developments of Buddhism and Hinduism to researching multi-

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[38] Jan Wisseman Christie, Asian Sea Trade between the Tenth and Thirteenth Centuries and its Impact on the States of Java and Bali, Himanshu Prabha Ray edited, *Archaeology of Seafaring: The Indian Ocean in the Ancient Period*, ICHR Monograph I, Pragati Publications, New Delhi, 1999: 221-270.

[39] Hermann Kulke, K. Kesavapany and Vijay Sakhuja edited, *Nagapattinam to Suvarnadwipa: Reflections on the Chola Naval Expeditions to Southeast Asia*, Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, Singapore, 2009.

religious cultural landscapes across the Oceans. Studies on sites such as Nagapattinam become significant as markers of not only trans-oceanic cultural currents, but also help define local and regional cultural and religious environments.

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